# The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

The White House said **Donald Trump** had discussed a new proposal to end the war in **Iran** with his national security team. Iran's plan would prioritise a ceasefire and reopen the Strait of Hormuz but delay talks on its nuclear programme. **Marco Rubio**, America's secretary of state, called it "unacceptable". Meanwhile, Friedrich Merz said America is being "humiliated" by Iran. Germany's chancellor has grown increasingly critical of America as the economic costs of the war mount.

**Hizbullah's** leader, Naim Qassem, ruled out giving up its weapons under any deal with **Israel**, rejecting a core Israeli condition for ending the war and withdrawing from southern Lebanon, further dashing hopes of peace. Despite a ceasefire, Israel said it carried out fresh strikes in Lebanon's Bekaa Valley, near the Syrian border, on Monday.

Cole Tomas Allen, the gunman arrested at the **White House Correspondents' Association** dinner, was charged with attempting to assassinate Mr Trump. Meanwhile **King Charles** met the president as part of his state visit to America. The monarch's assignment is ostensibly to commemorate the 250th anniversary of America's independence from Britain. However it has turned into a

mission to help salvage the countries' fraying "special relationship".

Mark Carney, **Canada's** prime minister, launched the country's first **sovereign-wealth fund**. The "Canada Strong Fund" will start with an endowment of C$25bn ($18bn) and invest primarily in domestic infrastructure. It is part of an effort to reduce Canada's dependence on America, whose tariffs have hit its economy hard. The two countries have not yet reached a deal.

**Afghanistan** accused **Pakistan** of "unforgivable war crimes" after Afghan officials said at least seven people were killed in strikes on a university. Pakistan dismissed the claim as "propaganda". If confirmed, the attack would be the first major incident of violence since the two countries held talks in China earlier this month. Pakistan declared "open war" against Afghanistan in February, blaming it for harbouring militants.

**Microsoft** will no longer have exclusive rights to sell **OpenAI's** products. Under the terms of a revised deal, the software giant will be offered the ChatGPT developer's models first, but they will then be made available to rival cloud providers including Amazon and Google. Microsoft will no longer pay OpenAI a share of the revenue it makes from selling the AI lab's services on the cloud.

The boss of **Wizz Air**, a Hungary-based airline, accused Gulf carriers of continuing to operate flights during the Iran war because of government pressure rather than independent safety assessments. Jozsef Varadi said rivals such as Flydubai did not "observe safety and security" and that he would not fly them himself. The unusually blunt attack comes as European airlines are cutting routes to the Gulf.

**Figure of the day:** 40%, the share of South Koreans aged 65 and over who remain in work. Read our story on why older people in East Asia are staying in the labour force.

Photograph: EPA

## How low can the yen go?

The Bank of Japan is expected to keep rates at 0.75% when it concludes its two-day meeting on Tuesday. America's Federal Reserve and the Bank of England, issuing decisions this week, will probably do the same. Most central banks have responded to the economic uncertainty caused by the Iran war by temporarily pausing cycles of cutting.

Analysts will be watching what the BOJ's decision means for the yen, which remains stubbornly weak despite two years of hikes (after 17 years of negative interest rates). At nearly ¥160 to the dollar, the currency is close to a three-decade low. In his press conference on Tuesday, the BOJ's governor, Ueda Kazuo, could lift the yen if he adopts a hawkish tone; a dovish one may push it lower still. Most analysts expect a rate rise in June. Yet a sharp tightening looks unlikely: Japan's high public debt and the prime minister's loose fiscal stance leave little room for the bank to move.

Photograph: Getty Images

## Purdue’s final reckoning

Purdue Pharma—arguably the biggest contributor to America’s opioid crisis—will return to court on Tuesday for a criminal sentencing. The drugmaker has admitted to deceptively marketing OxyContin, its highly addictive painkiller, and paying kickbacks to doctors to prescribe it. Purdue entered bankruptcy seven years ago, swamped by lawsuits from state and local governments and opioid users. The hearing is one of the final steps needed to unlock compensation.

Under the deal the firm and its former owners, the Sackler family, will pay up to $7bn to claimants over 15 years. Most will go to states and municipalities for drug treatment. Individuals will share a far smaller pool—around $850m—distributed according to the severity of harm. Anyone who lost a relative to an OxyContin addiction is expected to pocket between $7,000 and $48,000, an unsatisfyingly small resolution. And the public-health crisis itself is anything but resolved: around 45,000 Americans die of opioid deaths a year.

Photograph: Getty Images

## Can Starbucks perk up?

Starbucks reports its quarterly earnings on Tuesday. The world's largest coffee chain has recently looked lukewarm: ground down by rising takeaway orders (on which they earn smaller margins) and trendy upstarts like Blank Street, an American chain. Brian Niccol, Starbuck's boss, wants to return to the brand's coffeehouse origins by hiring more staff and encouraging customers to have their drinks in-store. So far, it seems to have worked: in its previous earnings, released in January, Starbucks reported rising sales in its stores for the first time in two years. The company's stock price has increased by more than 10% from the October average. Now analysts hope profits will heat up too.

Mr Niccol reckons coffee-drinkers want a welcoming "third space" outside work and home. Meanwhile Starbucks' main rivals—particularly Chinese companies like Luckin, Mixue and Chagee—prioritise efficiency: robots staff some of their stores. As these chains enter the American market, consumers' preference for comfort over convenience will be tested.

Photograph: Getty Images

## A new anti-fossil fuel forum in Colombia

The UN's annual climate summit in November was dominated by arguments over governments creating "roadmaps" for weaning themselves off fossil fuels (their pledge from 2023). When countries could not agree to commit even to talking about the concept or what it actually meant, the Colombian and Dutch delegations announced they would host their own international summit on the issue instead.

That conference begins on Tuesday, in the Colombian city of Santa Marta. Ministers from more than 50 countries will attend, alongside climate, economic and technology experts. Predictably, America, China and the Gulf states are not among them. Still, the countries represented collectively produce about a fifth of the world's fossil fuels, and turmoil in oil and gas markets has made transitioning to renewables a more attractive proposition.

Those frustrated by international climate diplomacy should not expect radical changes, however. The conference's aim is to come up with a "menu of solutions" to augment the formal UN process, rather than upend it.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

# Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [email protected]. We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

**Tuesday:** Which breed of horse, originating in England, was notable for its strength, being used to pull canal boats and brewers' carts, as well as farm equipment?

**Monday:** Which character is the main archenemy of the Fantastic Four, in both the comic book and film series?

*Real stupidity beats artificial intelligence every time.*

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***Terry Pratchett***